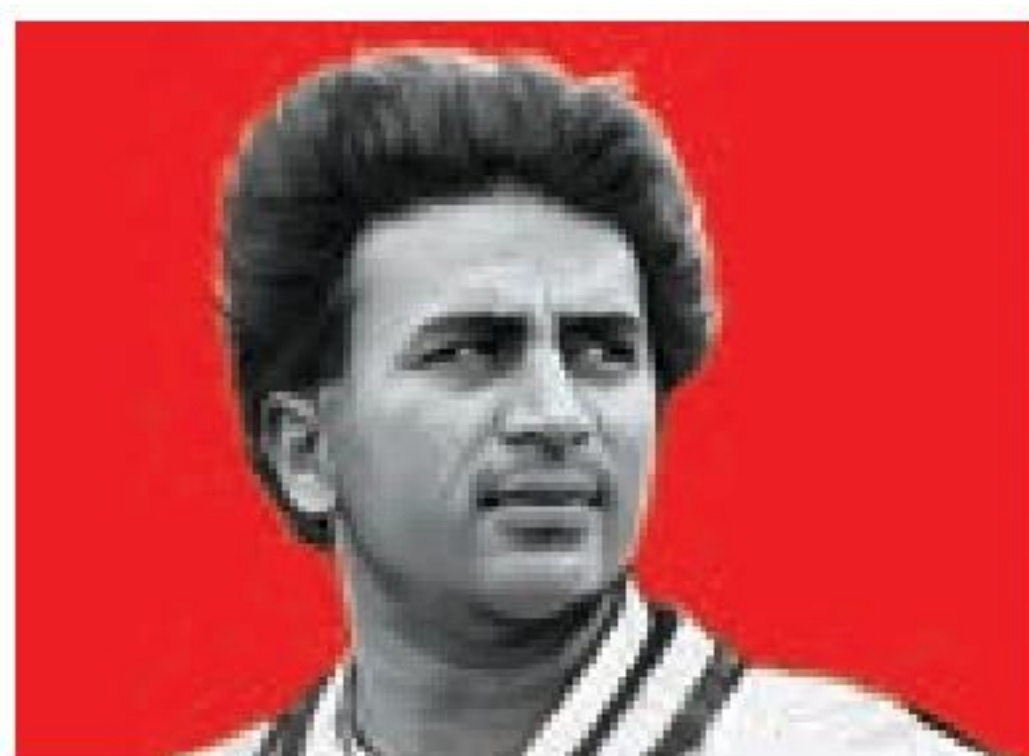




ON THE WRITE LINE

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NOTHING LIKE-FOR-LIKE IN LUNGI NGIDI'S SUBSTITUTE

Ngidi is a fast bowler who has shown great skill in bowling the **slower delivery** in the T20 format. As a batter, he doesn't have much to show, so how was a leg-spinner who could bat allowed to substitute for Ngidi?

Over the last few days, there has been some mind-blowing batting, searingly hostile fast bowling on surfaces with good carry to the keeper, incredible catching, especially in the deep, and also some of the dolliest catches ever seen being dropped. **There's been a heated debate about some decisions. All in all, a regular week in the IPL is what most would say.** The debate centres mostly around concussion substitutes, chest-high beamers, and obstructing the field. To this, add the definition of a wide ball for bouncers, and we have a serious debate on how some rules can be changed for the better of the game, not just the IPL.

Let's start with the concussion substitute. Firstly, the name should be changed to 'seriously injured' substitute. The rule was brought in for players who were incompetent to play the bouncer, so if they got hit on

the helmet and were thought to be concussed, the player could be substituted by another player outside the 11 whose speciality was similar to that of the one who was concussed. Over a period, this was also used for players who got hit on the head while fielding or struck the ground badly while attempting a catch and felt the after-effects. Fair enough, if the injured player is not going to be able to take further part in the game, then he could be replaced by another who did pretty much what the injured player did. But why restrict it only to a concussion? There are players who break a finger or an arm or a rib but cannot get a like-for-like replacement, even though they aren't likely or able to take any further part in the game. **Clearly, the substitute has to be for an external injury and not for muscular mishaps, which cannot be seen.** Yes, with modern technology, it is possible to see the genuineness and extent of a

muscular injury, but then there is always the possibility of this being misused. **What we saw in the Delhi Capitals game against Punjab Kings was Lungi Ngidi, who fell badly on his head while running backwards for a catch, being replaced by a leg-spinner who was also a decent hitter.** Ngidi, as those who follow the game know, is a fast bowler who has shown great skill in bowling the slower delivery in the T20 format of the game. As a batter, he doesn't have much to show, so how was a leg-spinner who could bat allowed to substitute for Ngidi? The only reason could be that Ngidi's slower off-breaks were the same speed as the leg-spinner's. Ngidi, by the way, doesn't even bowl the back-of-the-hand delivery, so there was nothing like-for-like in his substitute.

Then there were two back-to-back 'above-the-waist' deliveries bowled at speed during the Kolkata Knight